

Ancient-Medieval History

Around Gupta (185 BC- 700 AD)

Exam: UPSC CSE (Prelims)

1. Post-Maurya

Tier: tier3 • Weightage: 1.852 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 4 • Year span: 1996–2023 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:24

TopicDemandMap: Post-Maurya (185 BC–700 AD)

Explicit Subtopics Tested

1. Dynastic Transitions and Political Succession

- **Evidence:** [1611]
- Focuses on the end of Mauryan, Sunga, and Kanva dynasties, including assassinations, usurpations, and the rise of successor states (e.g., Andhras).
- Tests awareness of the sequence and nature of political changes after the Mauryas.

2. Buddhist Councils and Religious Developments

- **Evidence:** [1344]
- Covers the Buddhist Council during Kanishka's reign, including key personalities and its significance.
- Emphasizes the role of rulers and religious figures in shaping Buddhist history during the post-Maurya period.

3. Regional Buddhist Centres and Sects

- **Evidence:** [1002]
- Assesses knowledge of important Buddhist centres (e.g., Dhanyakataka), their regional locations, and associated sects like the Mahasanghikas.
- Requires understanding of the geographical spread and doctrinal diversity of Buddhism in this era.

4. Post-Mauryan Art and Sculpture Styles

- **Evidence:** [4774]
- Tests identification of characteristic materials and styles (e.g., use of green schist in Bharhut sculptures).

- Involves distinguishing features of regional schools of art that flourished after the Mauryas.

Logical Study Sequence

- 1 **Dynastic Transitions and Political Succession**
- 2 **Buddhist Councils and Religious Developments**
- 3 **Regional Buddhist Centres and Sects**
- 4 **Post-Mauryan Art and Sculpture Styles**

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Chronology and geography of post-Mauryan dynasties (Sunga, Kanva, Satavahana, Kushana, etc.)
- Basic Buddhist doctrinal developments and sects (e.g., Mahasanghikas)
- Key Buddhist councils and their outcomes
- Major artistic schools and their distinguishing features (e.g., Gandhara, Mathura, Bharhut)
- Map-based knowledge of ancient Indian regions and their historical significance

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Administrative systems and governance under post-Mauryan dynasties
- Economic developments: trade, coinage, and urbanization in the post-Maurya era
- Spread of other religions (e.g., Jainism, Brahmanism) during this period
- Foreign influences (e.g., Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Kushanas) on polity, culture, and art
- Literary and inscriptional sources from the post-Mauryan period

Notes:

- The PYQ count is limited (4), so subtopic granularity is constrained. The map above reflects only what is evidenced in the given questions.
- No direct questions on administration, economy, or foreign invasions are present, but these remain logical adjacent areas for future UPSC focus.

2. Gupta Empire

Tier: tier2 • Weightage: 5.556 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 16 • Year span: 1995–2021 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:24

TopicDemandMap: Gupta Empire (Ancient-Medieval History > Around Gupta (185 BC–700 AD) > Gupta Empire)

Explicitly Tested Subtopics

1. Language and Literature in the Gupta Period

- **Evidence:** 4777, 4864, 717
- **Notes:**
- Questions test the use of languages (Sanskrit, Prakrit) in plays, the flourishing of Sanskrit literature, and the association of key scholars (e.g., Kalidasa) with Gupta rulers.
- Focus is on both the medium of cultural expression and the patronage of literary figures.

2. Coinage and Economy

- **Evidence:** 4775
- **Notes:**
- Tested through identification of Gupta silver coins, reflecting economic practices and monetary terminology.

3. Trade and Urban Centres

- **Evidence:** 4773, 763
- **Notes:**
- Questions address major ports and towns involved in trade during the Gupta era, highlighting economic geography and commercial activity.

4. Art and Architecture

- **Evidence:** 2528
- **Notes:**
- Focus on surviving examples of Gupta period cave paintings, indicating the significance of visual arts and their locations.

5. Scientific and Mathematical Advances

- **Evidence:** 2729
- **Notes:**

- Tested through statements on mathematical concepts (sine, cyclic quadrilaterals) and surgical instruments, reflecting scientific knowledge during the Gupta era.

6. Inscriptions and Historical Sources

- **Evidence:** 2009, 4865, 4869, 4863
- **Notes:**
- Questions on the Allahabad Pillar/Prayag Prashasti and its content, as well as the portrayal of Samudragupta, test familiarity with primary sources and their historical significance.

7. Social Structure and Labour

- **Evidence:** 661, 4870
- **Notes:**
- Focus on forced labour (Vishti), its prevalence, and implications for social and economic organization during the Gupta period.

8. Political Geography and Administration

- **Evidence:** 4870, 4864
- **Notes:**
- Questions test knowledge of territorial extent, administrative changes (land grants, decentralization), and the impact on society.

9. Foreign Contacts and Pilgrims

- **Evidence:** 1747
- **Notes:**
- Tested through references to Chinese pilgrims (Fa-Hien, Hiuen-Tsang) and their observations, reflecting the Gupta era's international connections.

10. Literature and Drama (Contextual Reference)

- **Evidence:** 1609
- **Notes:**
- While not directly about the Guptas, the inclusion of ancient Indian drama (Mrichchhakatika) in the context of the period points to the broader literary milieu.

Logical Study Sequence

- 1 Language and Literature in the Gupta Period
- 2 Literature and Drama (Contextual Reference)
- 3 Coinage and Economy
- 4 Trade and Urban Centres
- 5 Art and Architecture
- 6 Scientific and Mathematical Advances
- 7 Inscriptions and Historical Sources
- 8 Political Geography and Administration
- 9 Social Structure and Labour
- 10 Foreign Contacts and Pilgrims

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Chronological placement of the Gupta Empire within Indian history
- Basic understanding of ancient Indian social hierarchy (varna, status of women, Shudras)
- Familiarity with the concept and importance of inscriptions as historical sources
- General awareness of the evolution of Indian art, literature, and science
- Knowledge of the broader context of ancient Indian trade networks and urbanization
- Understanding of the role of foreign travelers in reconstructing Indian history

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Religious developments and patronage (Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism) during the Gupta period
- Military campaigns and expansion under specific Gupta rulers
- Decline and disintegration of the Gupta Empire
- Comparative analysis with contemporary dynasties (e.g., Vakatakas, Western Kshatrapas)
- Women's status and daily life beyond elite circles
- Rural economy and agrarian structure under the Guptas
- Development of education and major learning centres (e.g., Nalanda)
- Technological innovations in metallurgy and other crafts

Notes

- The PYQ set is sufficiently broad to allow for meaningful subtopic division, but some areas (e.g., religion, decline) are not directly tested in the given questions.
- Some questions (e.g., on literature or drama) are tangentially related and serve as contextual anchors rather than direct probes into Gupta history.
- The map reflects only the tested and closely inferred areas; it does not speculate beyond the evidence provided.

3. Post-Gupta

Tier: tier2 • Weightage: 5.556 • Total Qs: 0 • PYQs: 14 • Year span: 1993–2022 • Model: gpt-4.1 • Updated: 2026-01-07 13:24

TopicDemandMap: Ancient-Medieval History > Around Gupta (185 BC–700 AD) > Post-Gupta

Explicit Subtopics Tested

1. Major Dynasties and Political Succession (Post-Gupta to Early Medieval)

- Identification of key dynasties and their geographical domains after the Gupta decline (e.g., Pushyabhutis, Maukharis, Maitrakas)
- Succession events and power transitions (e.g., usurpation after Harshavardhana)
- Evidence: 835, 4862

2. Harshavardhana: Events and Policies

- Major assemblies and religious policies (e.g., Prayag Assembly, Buddhism)
- Military campaigns and territorial limits (e.g., conflict with Pulakesin II)
- Evidence: 1347, 1607

3. Satavahanas: Identity, Inscriptions, and Succession

- Identification of Satavahanas in sources (e.g., Puranic epithet)
- Use of metonymics and patrilineal succession
- Inscriptions as historical sources
- Evidence: 4866, 4867, 4868

4. Central Asian Invasions and Impact

- Identification and origins of invading groups (e.g., Hunas, Torman)
- Effects on Indian trade and polity
- Evidence: 4778, 4772

5. Chronology and Eras

- Matching and identification of historical eras (e.g., Vikrama, Saka, Gupta, Kali)
- Evidence: 4776

6. Decline of Buddhism and Religious Developments

- Factors contributing to the decline of Buddhism in early medieval India
- Syncretism and absorption into Hinduism
- Evidence: 2599

7. Cultural and Intellectual Figures

- Identification of notable playwrights and their period
- Evidence: 842

8. Economic Instruments and Practices

- Understanding of financial instruments (e.g., Hundi) in the post-Harsha period
- Evidence: 746

9. Medicine and Science in Post-Gupta India

- Identification of key figures associated with medicine and science
- Evidence: 4779

Logical Study Sequence

- 1 Chronology and Eras (4776)
- 2 Major Dynasties and Political Succession (835, 4862)
- 3 Central Asian Invasions and Impact (4778, 4772)
- 4 Satavahanas: Identity, Inscriptions, and Succession (4866, 4867, 4868)
- 5 Harshavardhana: Events and Policies (1347, 1607)

- 6 Decline of Buddhism and Religious Developments (2599)
- 7 Cultural and Intellectual Figures (842)
- 8 Medicine and Science in Post-Gupta India (4779)
- 9 Economic Instruments and Practices (746)

Implicit Concepts / Prerequisites

- Understanding of the broader timeline from the late Gupta to early medieval period
- Familiarity with the political geography of ancient India (regions, capitals, dynastic centers)
- Basic knowledge of religious developments and sects (Buddhism, Vaishnavism, Jainism)
- Awareness of inscriptional and numismatic sources for reconstructing history
- Concepts of succession (matrilineal, patrilineal, metronymic) in dynastic histories
- Trade routes and economic exchanges in the post-Gupta era
- Role of Central Asian tribes in shaping Indian polity and society

Adjacent Subtopics (Potential Future Demand)

- Administrative structures and governance models of post-Gupta kingdoms
- Regional art and architecture developments (temples, sculpture) in the post-Gupta period
- Literary works and education systems under post-Gupta dynasties
- Social structure and caste dynamics in early medieval India
- Maritime trade and external relations with Southeast Asia
- Evolution of land grants and feudal practices
- Further details on the decline and transformation of urban centers

Notes:

- The subtopics above are strictly derived from the provided PYQs.
- Some subtopics (e.g., Satavahanas) appear due to overlap with the late Gupta and early post-Gupta period as reflected in the questions.
- The number of questions allows for moderate subdivision, but some areas (e.g., economic practices, science) are represented by single questions, limiting granularity.
- Adjacent subtopics are inferred based on logical extensions of tested areas, not on external syllabus lists.